"Oh no – the Turks!": Italy and the Islamic Mediterranean

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Spring 2025 / Office hours: TBD



Passed down through popular lore, the phrase "mamma li turchi!" is still known to Italians today. This course explores the history, culture, and contemporary politics of Italy through the lens of the country's relations with Muslims and Islamic societies in the Mediterranean region. We begin in the first millennium of the common era, when Muslims ruled over large parts of Europe, including Iberia and Sicily. We then move into the Renaissance period to cover Italy's extensive relations with Islamic empires such as the Mamluks of Egypt and the Ottomans of the eastern Mediterranean and North Africa (often simply called, "the Turks"). Moving into the modern period, we will examine how Italian national identity was molded in contrast to an imagined Muslim counterpart, tracing how these ideas informed Italian colonialism in North Africa. The last part of the course focuses on contemporary issues: over the past several decades and still today, Italy has maintained particularly close relations with Muslim countries in the region. Nonetheless, immigration and the supposed menace of Islam have come to play a large role in Italian politics today. We will study these topics using a range of sources including first-hand accounts (in translation), art, and film. Key themes in the course include conquest, coexistence, conversion, migration & immigration, trade, colonialism, national identity formation, the Cold War, and global political movements.

Learning outcomes

The main objective of this course is to question the "civilizational" divide between Europe and the Islamic World by exploring social and cultural relations that traversed religious and political frontiers over the course of Italian history. The Mediterranean, with special attention to its Islamic shores, will be debated as a fraught yet productive alternative framework for understanding Italian culture and history. Methodologically, students taking this course will learn how to carry out close readings of primary and secondary historical sources in order to construct arguments about the past and relate them to the present day.

Assignments & evaluation

Participation – 20%
Attendance is mandatory. Students should come to class prepared to discuss the readings.

Map quizzes – 20%
We will have four in-class map quizzes (see course schedule). Geography matters, folks!

Leading discussion – 10%

Each student, either alone or with a partner, will lead class discussion for a primary-source reading. You must come prepared to make *very* brief introductory remarks summarizing the reading and pose four well-formulated questions to the class.

Diary entry – 20%
1,000 to 1,200-words. This diary entry will be written from the perspective a history character, chosen from a list I make available. You may envision what an ordinary day looks like from the point of view of this person, or else you may choose to narrate a particularly important historical moment from their lives. You must show how historical figures viewed the world using categories and moral frameworks different from our own. The entry should touch on broader thematic questions that the course tackles.

Journal article / primary source analysis - 30%
1,500 to 2,000 words. Write an essay that offers a close reading of a primary source of your choice (a list of choices will be made available online). This essay should make an argument about the significance of the source(s) at hand by addressing the motives of the writer and identifying the intended audience for the text, as well as by drawing conclusions in light of background readings you have done for the course. You should demonstrate why the source is relevant or interesting to readers today, or address a key question raised by the source. Your selection must be cleared with me before you begin writing if it is not in the list of suggestions. Bibliography required. Alternatively, creative final projects will be considered but must be cleared with me.

*Extensions may be granted if requested at least 24 hours in advance of deadlines. You will lose 1/3 of a letter grade for each day past deadline an assignment is submitted.

- NOTE: ALL REQUIRED READINGS WILL BE UPLOADED ONLINE.

Course schedule

Part I: beginnings until 1800

Week 1 Course overview, the Rise of Islam	Session 1 ▪ *In class*: reading on the Mediterranean in world history Session 2 ▪ Strayer and Nelson, "The Worlds of Islam", *Ways of the World*, 2016, pages 363-375 (you may skim or read the rest). Thematic questions ➢ What is the job of a historian? ➢ What is the historical significance of the Mediterranean to world history? Is it a single region? Is it more productive to conceive of it as a boundary, a frontier, or in other ways? ➢ What was the impact of the rise of Islam on world history, and on the Mediterranean region?

Week 2 Muslim Sicily & the Crusades	Session 1 ▪ Dominique Valerian, "The Medieval Mediterranean", *Companion to Mediterranean History*, 77-90. Session 2 ▪ The memoirs of Usama ibn Munqidh, *The Book of Contemplation* (PS) <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ How did the balance of power in the Mediterranean shift around the year 1000? ➢ What was the role of the Italian maritime republics in this shift? ➢ What are the origins and impact of the Crusades?

Week 3 Conquest & *Reconquista*	Session 1 ▪ Molly Greene, "The Early Modern Mediterranean", *Companion to Mediterranean History*, 91-103. Session 2 ▪ Ibn Jubayr, *Travels*, on Norman Sicily (PS) ▪ *Map quiz 1: Mediterranean geography* <u>Thematic questions</u> ▪ What was the significance of the rise of the Ottoman Empire? ▪ What was the *Reconquista* and what was Italy's role in it?

Week 4 Mehmet the Conqueror: Renaissance Conversations	Session1 ▪ Claire Norton, "Blurring the Boundaries: Intellectual and Cultural Interactions between the Eastern and Western; Christian and Muslim Worlds", in *The Renaissance and the Ottoman World*, pp. 3-21. Session 2 ▪ Kritovoulous, *The History of Mehmet the Conqueror* (PS) ▪ Zorzi Dolfin, *Cronaca* (PS) <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ What is the role of the Renaissance in dominant narratives today about Western civilization? ➢ Who was Mehmet the Conqueror, and how did Renaissance ideas form a part of his political project?

Week 5 Piracy, slavery, & identity	Session 1 ▪ Listen to *Ottoman History Podcast* on Mediterranean piracy: https://www.ottomanhistorypodcast.com/2020/01/pirates.html Session 2

	▪ Natalie Zemon Davis, *Trickster Travels: A Sixteenth Century Muslim Between Worlds*, chapters 2 and 6, skim ch. 9. <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ How was identity different in the early modern period compared to how we experience it today? ➢ What were the major features of Mediterranean slavery, and what was its relation to piracy (or privateering)? ➢ What was the significance of religious conversion in this context?

Week 6 Visit to the University of Bologna Library archive of Islamic manuscripts	Session 1 ▪ Visit Islamic manuscript collection in Bologna University library. ▪ Duygu Yildirim, "Bevanda Asiatica: Scholarly Exchange between the Ottomans and Europeans on Coffee", *Journal of Ottoman Studies*, (2020): 25-47. Session 2 ▪ *Map quiz 2: Mediterranean states ca.1550* ***Diary entry due Thursday, March 6th at 5PM CET*** <u>Thematic questions</u> ▪ How did the medieval and early modern organization of Bologna correspond the religious imagination of its inhabitants? ▪ What is the difference between manuscripts and printed sources for historians?

Part II: towards today, 1800-present

Week 7 The *Risorgimento* & the modern era	Session 1 ▪ "Atlantic Revolutions," *Ways of the world: A brief global history* (eds. Strayer et al): ▪ [In class: watch *L'Italiana in Algeri*] Session 2 ▪ Anna Cento Bull, "Modernity and resurgence in the making of Italy," *Modern Italy,* 31-38. ▪ Camillo Benso (Cavour), "Railways in Italy," (1846) (PS). <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ What changes were portended by the rise of nationalism in the global context?

Week 8	Session 1

The origins of Italian colonialism	▪ *Ways of the World: A brief global history* (eds. Strayer et al): "Industrial Revolution and Colonial Endeavors". Session 2 ▪ Vanda Wilcox, "Imperialism and Irridentism in Liberal Italy", in *The Italian Empire and the Great War* (2012): pp. 18-40. ▪ Justifications for the Italian invasion of Libya (PS) <u>Thematic questions</u> ▪ What was the relationship between Italian colonialism and Italian nationalism? ▪ How did Italy, as a middle power, attempt to frame its colonial exploits differently from those of the British and French Empires?

Week 9 WWI & fascism's rise	Session 1 ▪ Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, "The Futurist Manifesto," 1909. Session 2 ▪ "What is Fascism?" from Patrick Zander, *The Rise of Fascism* (2016) ▪ Victoria de Grazia, *The Perfect Fascist* (2020), chapters 1 & 11 <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ What factors brought about the rise of fascism? What were the foreign policy positions of the movement?

Week 10 Geography and race in Italy's Mediterranean empire	Session 1 ▪ Haile Larebo, "Empire-Building and It's Limitations: Ethiopia (1935-41) in *Italian Colonialism* (2005): 83-94. ▪ [In class: watch *Lion of the Desert*] Session 2 ▪ Gebreyesus Hailu, *The Conscript : A Novel of Libya's Anticolonial War* (original composed in 1927). <u>Thematic questions</u> ▪ How did fascist Italy's colonial aspirations change in the 1930s? What was the prevailing economic and political logic of Italian colonialism? ▪ How were Middle Eastern countries and national movements changing during this time period?

Week 11 The American-style postwar order	Session 1 ▪ Anna Cento Bull, "A Blocked Democracy," *Modern Italy.* ▪ Luciano Monzali, "The Middle East in Italian Foreign Policy", pp. 68-73 (skim 68-70). Session 2 ▪ 1948 US National Security Council report on Italy: NSC-02 (PS) ▪ *Map quiz 3: Mediterranean countries ca.1950* <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ How did Italy's relationship with the Islamic Mediterranean change in the post- war period? ➢ What role did Cold War ideologies regarding the economy and the global order have in Italy's relations with Middle Eastern countries?

Week 12 Cold War currents: Oil & the Palestine question	Session 1 ▪ Luca Riccardi, "Italy's foreign policy and the Palestine question", in *Italy and the Middle East. Geopolitics, dialogue and power during the Cold War* (2021). ▪ [In class: watch *Il Caso Mattei*] Session 2 ▪ Mu'ammar Gaddafi, speech at Zuwara (1973) (PS) <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ What was the place of the Middle East and Italy in the global order, in particular in relation to NATO and the USSR?

Week 13 After the Cold War: economic stagnation, & the War on Terror	Session 1 ▪ "After the Cold War," teaching resource. Session 2 ▪ Oriana Fallaci, *The Rage and the Pride* (2002) (PS) <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ What did the end of the Cold War portend for Italy's relations with its Muslim neighbors? ➢ How were these changes affected by new global economic conditions? ➢ How did the "War on Terror" impact Italian identity?

Week 14 Immigration & Muslims in Italy today	Session 1 ▪ Asher Colombo, Gianpiero Dalla-Zuanna, "Immigration Italian Style, 1977-2018," Population and Development Review, Vol.45 (2019): 585-615. ▪ *Map quiz 4: Italian regions* Session 2 ▪ Watch *Io Capitano*, directed by Matteo Garrone (2023) https://dickinson.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://www.kanopy.com/en/dickinson/video/14715329 <u>Thematic questions</u> ➢ Consider the rise of "Lega Nord" in its political and economic context. What role did immigration play in its ideology, and how did this shift in recent years to become a mainstream question in Italian politics?

FURTHER INFORMATION

Attendance policy:
Every student is expected to attend all scheduled class sessions on time and be thoroughly prepared for the day's class activities. Dickinson-in-Bologna instructors compile regular attendance records for every course and take these records into account when evaluating student participation and overall course performance. Dickinson-in-Bologna faculty tolerate reasonable, but limited absences not to exceed more than one week's worth of classes (1-3 class sessions, depending upon how often the course meets per week) of accumulated absences in any given course due to personal travels, transport delay, and other related impediments. No documentation is required for such absences. The consequence of missing class beyond an accumulated week's worth of class is a reduction of your final grade by one grade increment per absence. For example:

- Your final course grade will drop (e.g. A to A-) for missing one class session beyond a week's worth of class.
- Your final course grade will drop (e.g. A to B+) for missing two class sessions beyond a week's worth of class.
- Your final course grade will drop (e.g. A to B) for missing three class sessions beyond a week's worth of class.
- Etc.

Absences due to sickness or medical emergencies may be excused separately only if properly documented. Late arrivals or early departures from class, sleeping or causing disruptions in class or during class activities can result in being marked absent from class.

Special accommodations:
If you require special accommodations/have special learning needs, please inform the instructor.

Academic integrity:
Academic integrity is a core value in this course (as in others). You are expected work independently in the pursuit of knowledge, conduct yourself in an honest and ethical manner and respect the intellectual work of your peers and faculty. You may review Dickinson College's Honor Code HERE. Violations may result in serious consequences.

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